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Restaurant Server Posture Related to Add-On Sales

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Research has reported that the size of a restaurant bill affected tip size and that nonverbal communication, involving body posture and eye contact, helped to establish rapport and personal credibility. Using a naturalistic setting, this study examined the relationship between restaurant server posture (standing or squatting) and the amount of sales. This study used servers in a moderately priced, national franchise restaurant. Results showed that servers who squatted next to the table had higher sales and spent more time interacting with the customers. These results suggest how servers might increase the size of the bill and thus increase tip income.

Servers[1] depend on tips for a major source of income (Lynn & Mynier, 1993). Research has shown that customers tip more depending on the size of their bill (Harris, 1995; Lynn & Grassman, 1990). This finding implied that servers could boost the amount of their income by selling higher priced beverages and appetizers that would increase the bill. Bodvarsson and Gibson (1994) also reported that gratuities depended on bill size and that bill size and the amount of service were related. Larger orders of beverages and food required greater amounts of service. Thus, implementing unobtrusive ways to increase the size of the bill should benefit servers by increasing the size of their tips.

This study examined strategies to increase the size of customers' bills for the purpose of boosting tips. Specifically, the effects of server posture on the number of specialty drinks and appetizers the customer bought were observed during the initial visit to the table. Servers usually stand next to the table when interacting with customers. Some servers, however, squat at the table. Research has shown that servers who squat at a table earn more in tips than those who stand (Lynn & Mynier, 1993). This posture brings the server's face closer to and in alignment with the customer's face. Leathers (1992) found a strong connection between body proximity and personal liking. Some investigators (e.g., Hargie, 1986a, cited by Knapp & Hall, 1992) consider body proximity, smiles, and eye contact as non-verbal reinforcers. By squatting next to customers, the server was virtually sitting next to them, establishing good rapport, and assuming a position of postural congruence. Research on body communication has found that postural congruence is linked to good rapport, and good rapport promotes more communication, giving the receiver the feeling of being liked (Argyle, 1975).

In addition to body posture, eye contact is essential for servers to sell successfully (Brown & Still, 1994). Research has shown that nonverbal cues, such as body orientation and eye contact increase personal credibility, a key to selling any product successfully (Leathers, 1992). Although previous research has shown that bill size affects tip size, no research to date has specifically reported about factors that might affect the size of the bill.

The purpose of this study was to determine whether a server's posture would affect the amount of add-on sales (drinks and appetizers) and thus increase bill size and the amount of the tip. Using naturalistic observation, the server's initial visit to a table was observed for posture, duration of time spent at the table during the initial visit, and the amount of items sold to the customers by the server. The hypothesis was that the servers who squatted would have higher sales and remain at the table for a longer period of time during the initial visit than servers who stood.

Method

Participants

Fifty-four patrons, seated at 21 tables in a moderately-priced, national franchise restaurant in the Midwest were participants in the study. Servers were informed about the study because the observer was also employed as a server at this restaurant and knew the servers personally. Servers were told that the study involved observing squatting and standing behaviors, but the hypothesis was not revealed to them prior to the observations. Four servers consented to participate. Two typically squatted at tables, and two typically did not. The servers who squatted waited on 11 tables, and the servers who stood waited on 10 tables.

Materials and Procedures

A watch with a second hand was used to time the initial visit to the table. Alcoholic and non-alcoholic spe-

[1] This article has been modified and reproduced for purposes of this assignment.

cialty drinks, as well as appetizers were an important part of the menu and advertised throughout the restaurant. Data were collected during high-volume evening hours. An "all-occurrences" sampling method was used. A server, who had previously agreed to be observed, was selected each day of observation, and the observer sat near that server's work area. The observer ordered a drink and did homework to remain inconspicuous to customers; she also made notes discreetly. In addition, that data were collected during high volume hours allowed the observer to be less noticeable to servers. Servers were also coded to preserve anonymity and were not told when they were being observed to avoid demand characteristics. During the server's initial visit to the table, the observer recorded the server's choice of squatting or standing and the length of time the server was at the table. Squatting behavior was defined as bending at the knees until the server's face was on the same level or below the seated customers' faces. Standing was defined as being in an erect position and looking down at the customer. Timing started when the server picked up the ticket left at the table by the host and ended when the server walked away from the table. The observer recorded all drinks and appetizers served at the table, as well as the prices of the items. This procedure was repeated for each table in the server's work areas. During a total of 10 hours of observation, each server was observed for 2.5 hrs.

Results

The affects of server posture on the amount of add-on sales were assessed with t-tests. Although differences in the total cost of drinks and appetizers per table as a function of server posture were not significant, $t(21) = 1.2$, $p > .05$, there were two outliars, with an extreme value in each condition. When these two extremely high scores were omitted and the data analyzed again, there was a significant difference between the amount of sales as a function of server position, $t(19) = 2.5$, $p < .05$. The customers of servers who squatted spent more in dollars on add-on items ($M = 5.60$, $SD = 2.53$) than those of customers who stood ($M = 2.80$, $SD = 2.51$).

In addition, there was a significant difference in the amount of time servers spent at the table on the initial visit, $t(19) = 2.71$, $p < .05$. The servers who squatted spent more time in seconds at the table ($M = 64$, $SD = 28$) than the servers who stood ($M = 34$, $SD = 19$).

The correlation between the amount of time spent at the table and add-on sales was calculated for each server posture. There was no significant relationship between time spent at the table and add-on sales for those who squatted at the table, $r(9) = -0.06$, $p > .05$). There was, however, a significant relationship for time spent at the table and add-on sales for those who stood, $r(8) = 0.65$, $p < .05$).

Discussion

The results supported the hypothesis that a server's choice of squatting or standing is related to the amount of add-on sales. These findings were consistent with a similar study conducted on server posture and tips (Lynn & Mynier, 1993), which concluded that squatting at the table did have an effect on the amount of tips the server received. The results were also consistent with previous studies about body communication and nonverbal cues as selling techniques (Argyle, 1975; Brown & Still, 1994; Leathers, 1992).

One reason for the present findings may be, as Argyle (1975) has pointed out, that assuming a position of postural congruence promoted more talking. This interpretation could also explain why servers in this study who squatted spent more time at the table than those who stood. Another interpretation is that spending more time with customers, and not squatting, leads to greater sales. However, there was no correlation between time spent at the table and add-on sales for the servers who squatted. On the other hand, the amount of time spent at the table may be a relevant variable for servers who stand. Collectively, the data suggest that those who stand may need to engage in more verbal behaviors, whereas those who squat may be successful with nonverbal contact.

A limitation in the present study was the confounding between posture and a selection factor among servers. Servers in the squat and stand conditions were determined by their usual way of serving. Although servers appeared to be similar on variables such as attractiveness and neatness, those who squatted appeared to be more outgoing and talkative than those servers who stood. This difference may account for the higher add-on sales. Using the same servers, randomly assigned to a posture condition, would eliminate the confounding problem.

Another limitation in the study was the servers' knowledge about the study and the observer's presence. Although the servers did not know who was being observed at any particular time, the observer's presence was enough to inform them that they could be under scrutiny. Observing naive servers would eliminate such a limitation.

The findings from this study might motivate servers to look more closely at the nonverbal behaviors they use when serving tables and at the options they have to increase sales and personal income. Larger orders result from using various unobtrusive, easily implemented nonverbal methods. Such methods may prove to be effortless and effective for increasing servers' income.

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